

Style Guide & Design Rationale

Digital Literacy Fundamentals — Two Visual Systems, One Course

Why This Document Covers Two Systems

Every other course in this portfolio uses one consistent visual system throughout. This course needs two, deliberately distinct from each other, because they serve opposite instructional purposes. The course shell (Lessons 1–5) needs to feel like the rest of the learner's LMS experience — familiar, low-stakes, consistent with the platform. The capstone's simulated desktop needs to feel like a different thing entirely — a real (if simplified) laptop environment — because the learner has to recognize what they're looking at as a stand-in for the actual device they'll eventually use unsupervised. Making the simulation visually indistinguishable from the LMS around it would undercut the entire instructional purpose of building it.

1. Course Shell (Lessons 1–5)

Element	Treatment	Design Rationale
Background	Warm kraft-paper texture, tan/beige tone — consistent with this portfolio's established visual identity.	Maintains a low-institutional, notebook-like feel already validated across this portfolio's other courses. No reason to depart from a working pattern for the teaching lessons.
Primary CTA	Solid green buttons, white bold text.	Consistent with the established system: high contrast, reads as go/positive without red's alarm connotation.
Header bar	Dark charcoal bar, course icon, lesson title, numeric progress counter (e.g. “2/6” counting lessons, not screens).	Numeric, literal progress — same rationale as the established system. Counts lessons here rather than screens, since this document set treats the lesson as the primary unit at course scale.
Typography	Rounded, high-legibility sans-serif for body copy and buttons.	Consistent with the established system — prioritizes plain readability given variable reading levels and possible corrective-lens limitations in this population.

2. Simulated Desktop (Lesson 6 — Capstone Only)

Element	Treatment	Design Rationale
Background	A neutral, generic desktop wallpaper — solid color or simple gradient, not kraft-paper or any LMS branding.	Deliberately breaks from the course shell's visual identity so the learner recognizes this as a stand-in for a real, external device, not another LMS screen.
Icons	Simple, universally recognizable icon shapes with a plain-language label beneath each, matching common OS conventions without copying any specific commercial	Icon + text label pairing is a platform-wide accessibility standard already established in the Accessibility & Inclusivity Checklist. Avoiding a copy of a specific real OS's branding keeps the simulation generic and

Element	Treatment	Design Rationale
	operating system's branding or trademarked icon set.	transferable rather than teaching “this one brand's laptop.”
Windows	Light gray or white window chrome with a visible, high-contrast close (×) and minimize (–) control in a consistent top-corner location.	Generous, unambiguous tap targets — consistent with the forgiving-tap-target principle already established for this audience. Consistent control placement reduces the discrimination burden once the learner has learned it once.
Taskbar	A persistent bottom or side strip, visually distinct from both the desktop and any open window, always visible regardless of what's open.	Directly supports the taskbar's instructional role as a persistent “home base” — see Task & Content Analysis, Lesson 5. Its constant visibility is the point, not a style choice.
Real-laptop labels	A small, consistently-placed text annotation on or near each interactive element (e.g., “This is a click”) that can be dismissed after the first few uses but remains available on request.	Directly implements the input-model decision from the Task & Content Analysis — the vocabulary has to be visible at the moment of the action, not just stated once in an earlier lesson.

3. Interaction Patterns

Course shell

Accordion cards for definitional content (mirroring this portfolio's established pattern), one item expands at a time. No hidden gestures without a visible tappable equivalent.

Simulated desktop

Single tap only — no double-tap-to-open, no long-press context menus beyond what's explicitly taught, no swipe gestures. Every action available in the capstone maps to exactly one of the skills taught in Lessons 2–5; nothing in the simulation should require an interaction the learner hasn't already encountered.

4. Content & Writing Style

Guideline	Applied Example
Second person, direct address	“Tap the folder icon to open it” — not “Learners will tap the folder icon.”
Plain language, no clinical/institutional phrasing	“This is what a click does” instead of “Demonstrate comprehension of primary input mechanisms.”
Every simulated action named with its real-world equivalent	“You just clicked — on a real laptop, this is done with a mouse or trackpad.”
Target reading level: roughly 8th–9th grade	Applies to all instructional copy, including button labels, on-screen prompts, and the real-laptop-equivalent annotations.

5. What Not to Change

- The course shell's kraft-paper system — keep it consistent with the rest of this portfolio's courses rather than introducing a third visual identity.
- The deliberate visual break between course shell and simulated desktop — collapsing them into one look would undercut the instructional point of the capstone existing as a distinct, laptop-like environment.
- Generic, non-branded icon and window styling in the simulation — replacing it with a specific commercial OS's exact look would teach one brand's interface rather than the transferable concepts underneath it, and would raise an unnecessary trademark question for a portfolio piece.